



All-purpose kit

Combat medics were expected to treat a wide range of problems. This medic's survival pack contained morphine sulfate lozenges for severe pain and tablets to treat seasickness, malaria, fever, diarrhoea, and sweating.

Evacuating the wounded

The availability of medevac, commonly called “dust off,” helicopters, and the proximity to the battlefield of well-equipped and staffed evacuation hospitals saved countless lives. The air ambulances were reconfigured UH-1 troop transports, known as “Hueys” or “slicks,” that could accommodate up to nine litters. They could be in the air within three minutes of receiving a call and could have their patients in a hospital within 15 minutes of lift-off from the landing zone (LZ).

Despite large red crosses on the aircraft, they faced intense enemy fire when extracting the wounded. Armed escort gunships provided suppressing fire, but many times medevac pilots ignored standard procedures and flew into hot LZs without cover. Sometimes they had to hover and hoist the litters. They flew day and night and in all types of weather and terrain, performing seemingly impossible rescues. The peak year for the number of patients evacuated by dust off was 1969, when 206,000 US, ARVN, other allies, and civilians were transported. The dust off pilots and crews and the medical corpsmen in each unit